



Looking Ahead

- A trip to India early on in Cameron's term will add momentum to the relationship and signal strong commitment
- A stronger push from the UK for expansion of the UN Security Council can work as a pivot for the relationship
- Focus on building links in education, trade and closer cooperation on intelligence sharing and learning from each other's best practices to combat terrorism
- Coordinated efforts to stabilise situation in Afghanistan, and a better understanding of their respective positions on China, Myanmar and Nepal

Cameron it will only expand further as he is personally committed to building on the India partnership," says Shiv Shankar Mukherjee, former High Commissioner to the UK.

But the relationship will require some tweaking. Britain is no longer the major global power it used to be. Faced with a serious economic recession, it is struggling to find a voice at key international forums. However, being a permanent member of the UN Security Council and the G-8, it still carries some weight. India's economic growth, global rise and expanding market make it imperative for both to

cooperate with each other on key issues. For India, a major gain may be that the Tories have strongly supported expansion of the UN Security Council, which can become the pivot of their relationship considering that India is expected to push for it full throttle once it becomes a non permanent member of the top UN body later this year. The continued support from an important permanent member, the UK, will help bolster India's chances. Second, in its fight against global terrorism, it has always found London more receptive than many of its European counterparts. In the last

few months, Britain has handed over a number of Indian fugitives to India. This cooperative approach is likely to expand under a new regime. New Delhi has also found Britain a dependable ally when it comes to putting pressure on Pakistan to stop terrorism and that will continue.

Another big unifier will be Britain's desire to understand China better, where they see India as a natural advisor and a partner who can be a counterweight to the Asian giant. In fact the two sides are setting up a formal dialogue on the rise of China. But there will be speed breakers; London will have to look for newer ways to engage India on issues such as Afghanistan, where the decision taken at the London conference to get Taliban in the mainstream didn't go down well with Delhi. There is also the ticklish issue of climate change. India has some reservations over the British position of asking the developing world to cut emissions without any first steps by the developed world. The differences led to a minor skirmish last year when the Indian Foreign Office took affront to a huge billboard on climate change outside the British High Commission in New Delhi, which the High Commission was forced to remove. India is also concerned with Britain's stronger immigration policy and a tougher visa regime, but this is not specifically targeted at Indians.

For a recession-hit British economy saddled with a huge deficit, the trade relationship will be a pivotal cog in the bilateral machinery. Bilateral trade currently stands at \$12 billion but there is tremendous scope for expansion. For India, another plus will be a major role played by the Indian diaspora which has won a record number of eight seats. Many prominent friends of India like Shailesh Vara, Priti Patel, Alok Sharma, Paul Uppal, Virendra Sharma and former Labour Minister Keith Vaz have been re-elected. While Indo-British ties are expected to be further strengthened, the real bilateral advantage for India will be that the Cameron-led government can now take lessons from India in the fine art of coalition management. ■